A Short History of Coffee

Chapter 1: Origins in Ethiopia

Coffee almost certainly began in the highland forests of southwestern Ethiopia, where Coffea arabica still grows wild beneath the canopy. A popular legend tells of a goat herder named Kaldi who noticed that his goats became restless and lively after eating red berries from a certain shrub. Historians treat the Kaldi story as folklore, because the earliest written versions appear many centuries after the events they describe.

What is better documented is that people in the region chewed the berries, mixed them with animal fat as a portable energy food, and brewed the leaves as a kind of tea long before roasted coffee existed.

Chapter 2: Yemen and the Sufi Monasteries

The first reliable evidence of coffee drinking comes from Yemen in the fifteenth century. Sufi mystics in the port region around Mocha drank a brew made from roasted beans to stay awake during long night-time prayers and devotions. The port city of Mocha became so closely associated with the trade that its name is still used for coffee today.

Yemeni growers guarded their monopoly carefully. Beans were usually parched or boiled before export so that they could not be planted elsewhere. For roughly two hundred years, almost all of the world's coffee passed through Yemeni ports.

Chapter 3: The Coffeehouses of Cairo and Istanbul

By the early sixteenth century coffee had spread to Mecca, Cairo and Damascus. Coffeehouses, known as qahveh khaneh, became places for conversation, music, chess and the exchange of news. Their popularity worried some authorities, and in 1511 the governor of Mecca briefly banned coffee, arguing that coffeehouses encouraged political gossip. The ban was soon overturned.

The first coffeehouses in Istanbul opened around 1554. Ottoman coffee was prepared by boiling finely ground beans in a small pot called a cezve, a method that survives today as Turkish coffee.

Chapter 4: Europe Discovers Coffee

Venetian merchants brought coffee to Europe in the early seventeenth century. Some clergy called it the bitter invention of Satan, but according to a widely repeated story Pope Clement VIII tasted it and gave it his approval. The first coffeehouse in England opened in Oxford in 1650, and London soon had hundreds of them.

English coffeehouses were nicknamed penny universities because, for the price of a cup, anyone could listen to learned conversation. Lloyd's of London, the famous insurance market, grew out of Edward Lloyd's coffeehouse, where ship owners and merchants met to share shipping news.

In Vienna, legend credits the first coffeehouse to the aftermath of the Ottoman siege of 1683, when sacks of beans were left behind by the retreating army. The Viennese café culture that followed became a model for the rest of central Europe.

Chapter 5: Plantations and the Colonial Trade

The Dutch broke the Yemeni monopoly in the late seventeenth century by growing coffee in Java, which is why Java became another nickname for coffee. A young coffee plant given to King Louis XIV was later carried to the Caribbean island of Martinique by the naval officer Gabriel de Clieu around 1720, and its descendants spread across the Americas.

Brazil became the world's largest producer during the nineteenth century, a position it still holds. The rapid expansion of plantations in Brazil and the Caribbean depended heavily on the labour of enslaved people, a history that is an essential part of the story of coffee.

Chapter 6: Modern Coffee

The twentieth century brought instant coffee, the espresso machine and global coffee chains. Italian inventors refined pressurised espresso brewing, and in 1938 Achille Gaggia developed a lever machine that produced the layer of crema now expected on a good espresso.

Today coffee is one of the most traded agricultural commodities in the world. Roughly sixty percent of production is arabica and most of the rest is robusta, which is hardier, more bitter and contains almost twice as much caffeine.